Table of Contents

Name of content	Page number
Abstract	3
Introduction	3
Significance of Topic	3
Findings from Research	4
Student Findings	4
Doomscrolling in Bangladeshi Students	4-5
Personal Reflection	5
Conclusion	5
References	5-6

The Impact of Doomscrolling on University Students' Academic Performance and Productivity

Abstract

Doomscrolling means continuous scrolling of social media pages filled with negative content and current events. This activity became extremely widespread during the period of the ongoing pandemic and it still exists today. The aim of the current research is to investigate the effects of doomscrolling on the academic performance and productivity of university students. Four recently published researches were examined and analyzed. All of them are based on the survey data from the students from both Pune, India and Bangladesh. There seems to be a tendency towards increased screen use by the university students. As a result, students become mentally exhausted and feel guilty about it, thus start scrolling more obsessively which leads to shorter attention spans and less time spent studying. Even though all of these studies were cross sectional, it is impossible to determine the causation, but it is possible to prove correlation.

Introduction

We start our phones for a brief moment only to suddenly realize that an hour has gone by and we are left feeling tensed and somewhat drained. The term doomscrolling became widely known in early 2020 when people began looking through their news feeds much more since lockdown started (Sharma et al., 2022). Doomscrolling indicates someone's continuous searching for negative news (Sharma et al., 2022). Algorithms of endlessly scrolling feed in social media ensure that it never stops.

University students usually feel the problem. Smartphones are omnipresent and students usually experience a lot of stress with exams and deadlines while they try to establish good study habits. Young people have more chances of falling victim to this issue since they are still in the process of brain development (Birotte, 2026). This study examines how doomscrolling affects university students' attention, academic performance, and productivity.

Significance of Topic

There are compelling reasons why this subject is important. First of all, students are avid users with nearly 30% of the Bangladesh sample spending over five hours on mobile devices (Ahmed et al., 2026). Also, this causes time loss and may impact students' emotional state, leading to stress and fatigue. Last but not the least, while educational establishments tend to treat social media as one concept, doomscrolling should be treated separately as a specific matter (Mali et al., 2026).

Findings from Research

Sharma et al. (2022) developed and tested the doomscrolling scale with 15 items. Their findings affirmed that doomscrolling is a separate phenomenon and it correlates to hypervigilance and problematic Internet use. The correlation with anxiety is r=.307, while the correlation with self-control values r=-.181. Birotte (2026) reviewed ten papers and found a correlation between doomscrolling and anxiety, cognitive overload, and procrastination. Kostroma et al. (2025) stated that problematic usage of TikTok is connected with procrastination and can negatively influence grades.
Mali et al. (2026) identified different components of doomscrolling. Loss of control correlated with screen time (β=.140) and psychological impact (β=.132). There was a cycle of doomscrolling causing exhaustion, guilt and reduced productivity which caused students to return to their phone.

Student Findings

A questionnaire with 14 questions was answered by 500 college students of the Pune area (Mali et al., 2026). All questions scored more than average. The most important factors were automatically opening apps, feeling guilty for excessive scrolling, and the desire to view personalized content. Students using their phones for 4-6 hours had an average score of 4.13 for compulsive scrolling, while students who spent 2-4 hours had a score of 3.35. This shows a borderline around 4 hours. Issues related to concentration and productivity were reported to be highly prominent in Bangladesh.

Ahmed et al. (2026) completed a survey looking at doomscrolling, sleep and academic burnout in 390 undergraduates. There were many mixed results. There was almost no direct correlation between doomscrolling and burnout (r=-.001). Those with high levels of doomscrolling actually reported less sleep issues which we suspect is due to self-report bias. Poor sleep correlated with increased burnout (r=.37). The model showed an indirect correlation. We cannot however prove causation due to the design.

Doomscrolling in Bangladeshi Students

This phenomenon holds particular importance for students from Bangladesh. The authors Ahmed et al. (2026) have observed that smartphones became a crucial tool for university students to learn, communicate and obtain information. Only around 4 per cent of respondents claimed to spend less than 2 hours on their mobile device. The questionnaire was sent via Facebook and WhatsApp groups, social networks often used by students to stay updated on classes and tests. This could create a problem. While checking some routine information in their group, students could fall into a trap of negative news consumption. Lack of sleep among Bangladeshi students is caused by heavy workloads, late night screen use, and the pressure from society. Although direct links between

doomscrolling and burnout have not been identified in this study, a number of factors imply this phenomenon.

Personal Reflection

While reading the articles, I was struck by how applicable the cycle of guilt was. It was listed among the most frequent options seen in the responses of those who doomscroll due to feeling guilty (Mali et al.). It is understandable why this happens; if I spend the evening on my phone, I feel guilty and, as a result, continue doomscrolling. As a university student in Bangladesh, I am aware of this problem among my peers. There are some issues with these studies. Many of them relied on self-reports, convenience/snowball sampling, and cross sectional designs.

The authors of the Pune paper indicated that they had a low reliability of the selected variables. It is impossible to say for certain whether doomscrolling is linked to academic performance, but it can be concluded that there might be a cycle to disrupt. Doomscrolling might be a consequence of stress among students.

Conclusion

Doomscrolling should not be regarded as trivial behavior. Research indicates that doomscrolling brings along with its compulsive behaviors, fatigue, feelings of guilt, and can limit productivity among students. In addition, doomscrolling can contribute to burnout due to the problem of sleeplessness. There are interesting findings regarding the research itself as well as the fact that there is no evidence of causation. Nevertheless, there are ways to overcome the problem. Students can limit their screen time, put their phones away at night time, and reduce the consumption of negative materials too (Birotte, 2026). Universities may introduce some digital wellbeing topics in their orientation and counselling. People recommend addressing students before they become excessively ardent doomscrollers (Mali et al., 2026). In the future, it is important to conduct longitudinal studies with the use of objective measures of sleep.

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